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At what should be a time for festivities across religions, regions and communities, India has been caught up in a macabre season of death. Shoppers across our cities should be flooding marketplaces and spending money with joy and abandon, but instead they are being made victims of violence and witnesses to tragedy. Every week, recent history repeats itself: a low-intensity bomb blast in an urban hub full of people killing both young and old, every death ending an innocent life. It has become all too distressingly routine.

It is now evident that our normal way of life is under sustained attack from the forces of terrorism. The terrorists are repeatedly hitting India at its most vulnerable spot: in the heart of its teeming cities, in places where everyone is just another face in a crowd.

The spate of arrests that usually follow every incident turn up the terrifyingly, faceless perpetrators of this everyday violence: young, educated males much like those any of us come across everyday. It is precisely this anonymity that is both frightening and dangerous for India.

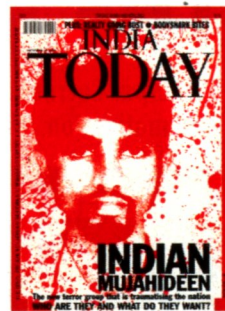
Last week, our Principal Correspondent Mihir Srivastava spent some time in the company of three of the accused in the Delhi blasts and was given a glimpse into the mind of terror. He came away shaken by the banality of their evil. The terrorists, all computer-savvy young men, described what they had done with a complete lack of emotion.

The terrorists were completely indoctrinated into the notion of being soldiers in a jihad but had only a vague sense of who 'the enemy' really was. They showed no remorse over causing death and mayhem, and said they would do so again, if given a chance. One man said he would plant a bomb in a market even if his mother was shopping there.

Our cover story, an in-depth analysis of India's terror networks, grew from Srivastava's account of his meetings. Editor-at-Large S. Prasannarajan travelled to Azamgarh in eastern Uttar Pradesh, now known as the factory of terror. Associate Editor Sandeep Unnithan looked at the new homegrown terror industry and Special Correspondent Shafi Rahman at the impact the incidents and the arrests have had on the Muslim community as a whole.

This is our fourth cover story on terror in the last five months; our coverage of the Bangalore and Ahmedabad blasts carried the provocative headline, 'Impotent India'. More than anything else, we wanted to shake our leadership out of its sloth and make fighting terrorism a top-priority, bipartisan agenda. There is no other solution but to get tough on terror. India must adopt a policy of zero tolerance, enact and implement laws required to capture the culprits and bring them to speedy justice and swift punishment. It's time we stopped being victims.

(Aroon Purie)



Our Sept 2008 cover